









ART

# WAYS OF SEEING

A MAJOR EXHIBITION OF THE WORKS OF ARTIST AND PHOTOGRAPHER **LALIT MOHAN SEN** AT EMAMI ART, KOLKATA, INTRODUCES HIS OEUVRE TO A NEW GENERATION OF VIEWERS

Pernicious and ruinous though its effects may have been, colonial rule, thanks to rail connectivity, unwittingly enabled people from remote corners of the Indian subcontinent to venture forth, often braving untold hardships, to seek a new life in strange and occasionally hostile lands. The life of Lalit Mohan Sen (1898-1954), an almost forgotten but immensely talented artist and photographer, is a perfect example of such an individual who hailed from Santipur, a town in Bengal famous for its exquisite handwoven textiles.

His grandnephew, Prabartak Sen, had a biggish collection of Sen's works and effects, but had Emami Art, Kolkata, not organised the comprehensive exhibition *Lalit Mohan Sen: An Enduring Legacy* (on till September 30) that covers a wide range of his oeuvre from drawing and painting to photography, graphic prints, commercial art and sculpture, he might have sunk into oblivion. The black-and-white silver gelatin prints are in surprisingly good condition and the exhibition has been curated in consultation with Debdutta Gupta, assistant professor at St Xavier's College, Kolkata. Archivist Arkaprava Bose wrote the accompanying text.

During a malaria outbreak, Sen's elder brother took him to Lucknow, where he spent most of his life. Here, he joined the Government School of Arts and Crafts in 1912. He moved to London on a government scholarship and came into his own as an artist and photographer. In 1925, he studied at the Royal College of Art in London, under the tutelage of Sir William Rothenstein.

It was only in England that Sen tried photography and in 1925 was elected a member of the Royal Photographic Society of Great Britain. Exhibitions were held extensively of his work in India and abroad. Queen Mary bought his painting 'Potter Girl' from the Royal Academy Exhibition in London. His woodcuts of Rabindranath Tagore and Mahatma Gandhi are part of the Victoria & Albert Museum's collection. His photographs were part of the Royal Photographic Society's annual exhibitions and its journal. When Sen returned to Lucknow, he taught at his alma mater for 25 years and became its principal in 1945.



**Realism was Lalit Mohan Sen's forte and he excelled in portraiture and landscape painting**